

THE BIRYANI PROMISE

Gemini

ACT I

1 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

1

The rich, spiced aroma of Chicken Biryani fills the air. Sunlight streams through the open window, catching the dust motes dancing above a steaming pot.

MOTHER (40s, tired but loving) stirs the pot with a large wooden spoon.

FATAK (14, energetic, entirely focused on his stomach) bounces on his heels behind her, holding a large empty plate.

FATAK

Is it ready? The aroma is driving me mad!

MOTHER

Patience, Fatak. The rice needs to breathe.

FATAK

I cannot breathe without it! You know it's my fuel. Chicken biryani, every single day. That's the rule of life.

MOTHER

(Sighs, smiling)
A very expensive rule. Here.

She heaps a massive mound of Biryani onto his plate. Two large chicken legs sit atop the mountain of fragrant rice.

2 INT. DINING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

2

Fatak sits alone at the table. He attacks the food with zero eating discipline, rapidly shoveling spoonfuls into his mouth.

Beside him sits a steaming cup of CHAI.

FATAK

(To himself)
Nothing else matters. Just this.

He takes a long, loud sip of tea, leaning back in absolute gluttonous satisfaction.

ACT II

3 EXT. FATAK'S STREET - EVENING**3**

The sun is setting, casting long, golden shadows across the pavement. The evening breeze rustles the leaves of a large Banyan tree at the end of the street, bringing a sudden chill.

Fatak and his friend RAJU (14) are playing catch with a worn-out tennis ball.

RAJU

Think fast!

Raju hurls the ball with sudden urgency. It sails high over Fatak's head and drops over the crumbling brick wall of the neighboring, abandoned compound.

FATAK

Ah, Raju! Now I have to go into the overgrown lot.

RAJU

Hurry! It's getting dark.

4 EXT. NEIGHBORING COMPOUND - CONTINUOUS**4**

Fatak climbs over the low wall and drops into the thick, untamed weeds. The sounds of the busy street immediately fade, replaced by the chirping of crickets and the quiet rustle of nature.

He searches for the ball in the fading twilight.

Suddenly, he freezes.

Through the tangled branches of a bougainvillea bush, he sees an OLD MAN sitting on a cracked stone bench.

The Old Man is frail, wearing tattered, threadbare clothes. In his trembling hands is a small, chipped bowl containing a mere handful of plain, watery white rice.

Fatak hides behind the bush, holding his breath.

The Old Man doesn't complain. He eats the meager portion of rice with intense care, picking up every single grain as if it were precious. He pauses, looking up at the evening sky, taking a slow, deep breath, finding a quiet dignity in the moment despite his profound lack of resources.

Fatak looks down at his own stomach, then back at the Old Man. The memory of his careless, daily mountain of Biryani flashes vividly in his mind. The contrast hits him like a physical blow.

The ball rests at Fatak's feet. He slowly picks it up, the joy of the game completely gone. A sharp realization of the world's harsh reality takes its place.

ACT III

5 INT. DINING ROOM - THE NEXT AFTERNOON

5

The same afternoon sunlight. The same steaming cup of tea.

Mother walks in and places the usual, massive mountain of Chicken Biryani in front of Fatak.

MOTHER

Eat up quickly. You were so quiet
after your game yesterday.

She walks back to the kitchen.

Fatak stares at the plate. The aroma is there, but his appetite has vanished. He picks up a spoon and simply moves the rice around.

He closes his eyes and sees the Old Man carefully, gratefully eating his plain rice.

Fatak acts with sudden decisiveness. He pushes the heavy plate away and grabs a smaller, empty bowl from the center of the table.

With deliberate care, he transfers exactly HALF of the Biryani into the small bowl, leaving the rest untouched on the platter.

Mother walks back in, wiping her hands on a towel. She stops dead in her tracks, shocked.

MOTHER

Fatak? Are you sick? You haven't
devoured it yet. And why is it
separated?

Fatak looks up. His eyes are clear, filled with a sudden maturity and purpose.

FATAK

I am not sick, Ma. I am just...
awake.

MOTHER

Awake to what? It's your favorite.
Chicken Biryani.

FATAK

It is. And I am grateful for it. But
I don't need this much. Look at this
mountain. It's too much for one
person while others have absolutely
nothing.

MOTHER

What are you talking about?

FATAK

Yesterday, I saw an old man making do with a handful of plain rice. He ate it with such care, just sitting quietly under the trees. It made me realize how much I take for granted. My greed was blinding me.

Fatak looks down at the smaller, modest portion in his bowl.

FATAK (CONT'D)

From today, I will practice eating discipline. I will eat only half of what I usually demand.

MOTHER

But you are a growing boy!

FATAK

I will grow better on less. This frugality... it's a promise to myself. If I embrace a minimalist way, this same quantity of food will last us twice as long. And maybe, in some small way, choosing not to consume everything will mean there are more resources left in the world for someone like that old man.

Fatak reaches into his pocket and pulls out a small notebook and a pencil.

FATAK (CONT'D)

I'm going to write this promise down. Words make things real. They help us commit, and maybe if others read it, they'll understand too. It's how we can work together to change things.

He carefully writes his vow on the blank page, acting immediately on his realization.

Mother watches him, her worry melting into profound respect. She steps forward and places a gentle hand on his shoulder.

Fatak takes a small bite from his halved portion. He chews slowly, consciously appreciating the life-giving nourishment of every single grain.

FADE OUT.